

"We are trying to protect those who have been threatened."

DEVAN BHARTI, DEPUTY COMMISSIONER OF POLICE, CRIME

redevelopment, the underworld is using its muscle power to make a killing. The scramble for space now is no longer between those who are looking for a roof, but between those who want to build it. As many as 1,000 redevelopment projects are slated to begin in the city and another 1,600 are in the pipeline. There is, thus, big money in the business and the share of the underworld is anybody's guess.

Early this year, the police received inputs that don Dawood Ibrahim is using his sister Haseena Parkar to pump money into Mumbai's real estate, Slum Rehabilitation Authority's (SRA) projects being their focus areas. Parkar and two builders, Krishnamilan and Sandeep Shukla were arrested by the crime branch after a case of cheating and forgery was registered against them on the complaint of Vinod Avlani, a real estate broker and builder Jayesh Shah. The two had been promised the development rights of two major SRA projects and had been given forged transfer documents. Deputy Commissioner of Police, Crime, Devan Bharti says, "It not only confirms that the underworld is investing its money in the city's real estate but also points to the comfort level of the builders in accepting them as a partner." Another case, which further proved the symbiotic relationship between the dons and builders was unearthed in Chembur in November 2005. The cops were tipped off by a builder who was being threatened by don Chhota Rajan. "Investigations revealed that Rajan's wife Sujata Nikhalje was executing several redevelopment projects in the area under the banner of Khushi Builders and Developers," explains S. Sandhor of the crime branch.

Investigations reveal that most of the gangs have specific areas of operation. "Dawood's gang is active in South Mumbai. In areas like Andheri and Bandra, it's Ravi Pujari's gang, while Rajan's gang is active in Chembur and Navi Mumbai," informs Bajrang Parab, assistant-police inspector, who is investigating



MODUS OPERANDI

- A builder in partnership with the underworld, locates a prime plot and informs them.
- If it is a slum area, the don uses his goons to evict the dwellers.
- In case of private ownership, the landlord is forced to sell the plot at a throwaway price.
- In redevelopment cases, they either force the builder to transfer the project to their partners or ask for profit-sharing.
- On papers, the builder is the front man. The underworld enters the fray only to sort out hitches.
- The deal is verbal and varies from project to project.



UMESH GOSWAMI

Parkar's case. The modus operandi in most cases is identical. A builder, in partnership with a don, locates a prime plot and informs him. If it is a slum dwelling, the underworld uses its goons to get the land vacated. In case of private ownership, the landlord is forced to sell the plot at a throwaway price. In redevelopment cases, the underworld tries to lobby for the plot through its partner builders. They either force those handling the project to transfer it to their partners or ask for profit sharing. As for the paperwork, the builder is the front man and the underworld enters the fray only to sort out hitches. The deal is verbal and varies from project to project. Most builders also turn to the underworld for financial aid for mega projects. "Prominent builders comply with profit sharing demand of the don, while small timers back off," says Bharti.

Most builders agree that a new trend of keeping the underworld "happy and at bay" is fast emerging. Builder Terrence D'Souza, an activist for the builder lobby in Malad confirms the underworld-builder nexus. "The underworld, a builder's foe till four years ago, has now turned into a partner," he says. Builder Atul Agrawal, who has been a victim of these dons says, "Not just Dawood or Rajan, small-time dons too are fast entering the race to get a piece of the pie."

The police with all this, have their hands full. "On one hand we are keeping a vigil on builders announcing big projects, while on the other we are protecting those who have been threatened for rejecting partnership offers," says Bharti. In the past eight months, the Mumbai Police have provided security to over 80 builders, of which 20 were provided the cover in August and September alone. A city builder on the condition of anonymity says, "While the police is watching out for builder-underworld nexus, the underworld is on the lookout for builders who have bagged or are executing mega projects." The race is on. ■